

RSM — Just-DDJ Chain (v9.3)

A translation. :: denotes imperfect structural correspondence — never identity, translation-equivalence, or congruence; substitution is forbidden. [G] marks what is attested in the Guodian bundles (~300 BCE); [R] received-text or Mawangdui only.

One discipline throughout: no character enters a derivation, and no structure overrides the strips.

The opening as a register declaration

可 and 常 are the explicit and implicit registers. 常 is what holds frame-independently, parameter-free — the structural requirement itself. 可 is anything framed, indexed, instantiated: a statement, a traversal, a measurement, a name.

The received text opens by declaring this and nothing else. 道可道非常道 splits the structure: the entailment as such is not any framed traversal of it. 名可名非常名 splits the naming, and it is the line that closes the escape: one might otherwise think the invariant has a right name. It does not. The moment you name, you are indexed; every name is 可名.

That licenses the notation these chains use. 有 and 無 are names — 可名, an indexed instance. X and Y are not names of form and void; they are the slots the two modes occupy. The implicit register runs on slots, the explicit register on words, and the second line is why.

Attestation, carried. This is the clearest register declaration in the text and it sits in the one chapter absent from the strips. What the oldest witness carries is the same distinction taught by demonstration rather than statement: chapter 2 gives six conjugate pairs, no definitions, and lets the one relation be induced. The received arrangement declares the limit of the instrument; the older one commands its abandonment (絕智棄辯) and then shows the pairs. Candidate reading of the difference: a scope note gets prepended when readers have begun taking the 可 for the 常 — the same drift the 也-erosion and the staged 有生於無 record elsewhere.

The referent: 道

道 :: **the recursive structural model itself** — the structure entailed by P₀'s standing non-obtaining ("P₀ has never obtained, does not obtain, and will never obtain" — three tenses as the in-frame rendering of a tenseless modal fact; the text's tenseless grammar states it

natively). 常道 :: the entailment as such, unindexed. 可道 :: any framed statement or traversal of it. Consequences: 道法自然 — a structure grounded in an impossibility needs nothing to hold it up; an impossibility cannot lapse, be consumed, or require maintenance (谷神不死, 用之不勤 as entailments, not praise). In Chapter 25's dual styling, 道 is the model and 大 its first instance, R_1 .

The opening: 道可道非常道 [R — Ch. 1 not in Guodian]

Heading-and-theorem: the frame-relative is not the frame-independent. $\forall X: \text{可}X \text{ 非 常}X$.

- 常 :: frame-independent, parameter-free (register marker; not “eternal”). The oldest stratum reads 恆 (persisting-across); see the checksum item on 恆/常.
- 可 :: frame-relative, parametric, indexed within the frame. (The modes are magnitudes; a sign is an indexed comparison. This is the text's own testimony — its conjugate pairs are co-present magnitudes throughout, and no negative quantities appear anywhere in it.)
- 非 :: the divergence of two registers around a shared invariant. In the only copular uses the text contains (Ch. 1's two), 非 stands between two readings of one term — 可道 非 常道 — and its middle is the invariant both flanks share. The survey: 非 is rare (on the order of six tokens in five chapters); the non-copular tokens are rhetorical (Ch. 7), purposive (Ch. 65), class-negation (Ch. 31), predicative (Ch. 53); 是非 as a compound does not occur; **no token negates between conjugate opposites**. (survey run against the corpus; Guodian graphs still to be verified against facsimiles)

The corpus contributes here by **resistance**, which is the one thing this chain may supply as evidence: the text refuses the mirror-negative reading, in that the construction such a reading predicts is absent from every token. Structurally the mode-swap's fixed point is the invariant itself, which is what the copular grammar puts in the middle. The two accounts agree; only the philological one carries weight.

Line 2: 名可名非常名. 常名 :: $XY = 1$, the unindexed law; 可名 :: $X_n Y_n = 1_n$, the same law indexed. The 可/常 split applied to the law itself.

Lines 3–4. The Mawangdui manuscripts read 萬物 in both clauses (the Shiji quotes the line that way; 天地 is the received substitution). One referent, twice related: **始 and 母 are the two relations** the unnamed and the named bear to the ten thousand things — what conditions them and what keeps constituting them — i.e., the derivation's two mechanisms: identity-through-opposition at the ground; generation at the paradox thereafter. 始 :: O_n (the unmet origin, prior to any position); 母 :: P_n (the generative persisting locus, the parent-side of 生). Shared 女 :: the center-role genus; different determinatives :: the two species. [R]

The methodology lines (常無欲以觀其妙 / 常有欲以觀其徼) [R]: two observational vantages, one from each face, both required — the parallax method stated inside the text. 欲 ::

directed orientation, zero agency; 妙 :: relational pattern (the 無-vantage); 徼 :: boundary (the 有-vantage). Philological exposure carried: this reading requires the split parsing (常 無, 欲...); the Mawangdui phrase-grouping leans toward the unit parsing (恆無欲...), and no older stratum arbitrates. The reading is falsifiable at the manuscript layer and is cited only with that exposure attached.

有無相生 [G — Ch. 2, slip A15; 亡 for 無; the shorter formulation]

有 :: the form mode; 無 :: the void mode — two co-present magnitudes with the gradient reading 有 × 無 = 1_n. Neither reaches zero; each is constituted by the other; every position carries both. Void is not zero: zero is the center, where both modes would vanish; 無 as mode is a bounded, shaped, functional magnitude (Ch. 11: 有之以為利, 無之以為用 — the conserved product in nine words). Guodian 亡 (relational absence) fits the mode reading better than received 無; the drift 亡→無 runs toward exactly the confusion this register discipline guards against.

Chapter 2 is also the method: no definitions, six conjugate pairs listed, each arising mutually, the one relation induced from six instances — how a mutually-constituted circle is entered, since it cannot be derived into from outside. The chapter with the oldest witness carries the structural heart; the staged cosmogony (Ch. 42) is absent from the strips.

Chapter 40 [G — slip A37; the scored test]

The slip reads: 返也者道僮也 / 溺也者道甬也 / 天下之勿生於又生於亡。

- **The engine lines are definitions.** Both carry the 也者...也 formula — the classical definitional construction: “Returning — it is the pattern’s movement; 溺-ing — it is the pattern’s function.” The received text strips the stamps to bare assertions; the 也-erosion, documented at the two most load-bearing lines in the text.
- **返** (return-in-motion, the walker radical), where the received has 反. 反/返 :: the turn along G around the unmet center — circulation, the in-frame face of the engine. Which of 反/復 names return-of-structure versus return-of-place is a checksum item; the two-returns theorem it was keyed to is explicit on the math side, so the checksum may be a purely lexical question.
- **溺 — attested-uninterpreted.** The graph is 溺, not 弱 (the inventory’s 弱 was the received normalization). The interpretive ladder is mandatory and unfilled: (1) 溺’s Chu-period semantic range; (2) its local reading, framework-blind; (3) only then any correspondence. A37 is the highest-projection-risk location in the corpus. No :: is assigned.

- **The preregistered test, scored positive.** The preregistration: if the strip reads symmetrically (生於有，生於亡), the older text sits on the modal side and the received hierarchy (有生於無) is the later emendation. The transcription shows **no second 有**: born of 有, born of 亡 — the balanced parallel. The oldest witness reads co-emergence; the staged arrow was added in transmission. Threats to validity, carried: (i) haplography — a repeated 有 is the classic eye-skip environment; against it, the 3+3 balance, the definitional framing of the preceding lines, and Ch. 2's 相生 on the same bundle; (ii) **the Mawangdui bracket — whether the silk texts carry the repetition dates the emendation; the facsimiles are unchecked, and the date is not to be cited until they are.** The finding stands on the transcription; only the dating waits. Consequence: 生 at this line reads as co-emergence, and the three-forms taxonomy below is untouched.

The cluster: 玄 / 牝 / 玄牝 [G — 玄 attested, slip A08; 玄牝 R]

玄 :: Paradox :: P_n . 牝 :: generative. 玄牝 :: generative paradox :: P_0 . The compound is compositional — the character for paradox plus the character for generative capacity computes the name of the generative paradox — so the assignment is motivated, not brute. The differentiator: every P_n has two faces (in-frame, the locus circulation organizes around; trans-frame, the origin a child organizes around); P_0 , unframed, has no in-frame face — it is *purely* generative, and 牝 marks that purity (可以為天下母; 玄牝之門是謂天地根: the mother of the whole tree). 玄之又玄 :: **the species iterated** — paradox at every recursion of the tree: the reduplication reads as the recursion itself. 眾妙之門 (Ch. 1) and 玄牝之門 (Ch. 6): 門 at exactly the two places the structure has gates — the recursion's and the ground's.

The three generative forms, one ratio, three mechanisms, never conflated: (1) entailment-生 :: the ground, $P_0 : O_1$ (道生 — 道 is not a mother; P_0 has no prior state); (2) parturition-生 :: $P_n \rightarrow P_n, O_{(n+1)}$ (severance with a persisting parent); (3) 相生 :: mutual constitution within the frame. 生 $\neq$ 相生; entailment-生 $\neq$ parturition-生.

The count: 道生一，一生二，二生三，三生萬物 [R — Ch. 42 not in Guodian]

Exposition-order, never event-order. 一 :: the first distinction; 二 :: the two modes (nothing added — the two came with the one); 三 :: **the pair plus its bond** — the text's own gloss in the next line, 沖氣以為和: the blend, not a third mode and not a third axis. The three is P_n — the pair with its bond; the text's exposition counts children from there, which is commentary on how it counts and not a structural siting, since generation has no address. 三生萬物 because only the pair-with-its-bond is able to be referred to. The chapter's staging is absent from the oldest witness; read as a timeline it re-imports what the strips refuse.

天地不仁; 守中 [mixed strata — only the bellows lines are strip-attested (A23)]

天地 :: G_n ; 天地不仁 :: no preferred position along the gradient [R]. Extended to the tree: no preferred frame — every trunk is a branch of its parent and every branch a trunk to its children, save a root (each obtained tree is rooted; O_1 's parent-side is P_0 , an impossibility, not a frame; the ground is exempt by mechanism, not favored). The bellows (虛而不屈，動而愈出) :: the functional void, strip-attested [G]. 守中 :: B_n — the balance line, which reaches from O_n through P_n and which nothing occupies; descriptive, not prescriptive [R].

弗居 [G — slip A17; the strongest strip-attested match in the chain]

成而弗居: completes, yet structurally-cannot-dwell. 成 :: completion in the practical register (the completion is real); 弗居 :: the origin-denial (弗, structural impossibility — exactly not 不, contingent negation). The engine's two-denial structure, in two characters, on a strip. 無為 :: aligned persistence; 為 :: effortful action under misalignment.

此兩者同出而異名 [R]

Same origin, different register — the slice identity is its sharpest reading: the gradient and the orbit are literally 同出 (one law) 而異名 (two slices, two names); 同謂之玄 — the shared origin is viewed at P_n , where the slices coincide: 玄's own locus. Two names for one law is exactly what an indexed second reading is.

The 法 regress [G — slip A23]

人法地，地法天，天法道，道法自然. 法 :: the child-parent structural relation — pattern-taking, not substance-transfer, which is what the cross-frame share is. 道法自然 :: the terminus of the regress of grounds — the model takes its pattern from its own self-sufficiency, because beneath an impossibility there is nothing to stand on. 域中有四大: the fourth term 王 not yet derived.

The anthology as curriculum [G]

Bundle A's first unit is one physically continuous written entity (the text runs across slips; internal order secured): $19 \rightarrow 66 \rightarrow 46 \rightarrow 30 \rightarrow 15 \rightarrow 64 \rightarrow 37 \rightarrow 63 \rightarrow 2 \rightarrow 32$. It opens with 絕智棄辯 — discard cleverness and *disputation* (the Guodian wording; the received retargeting at Confucian virtues is the later layer) — passes through 為無為 (practice the

paradoxical mode), and arrives at the six pairs (the structural primer). Entrance, practice, structure: the received arrangement opens by *declaring* the limit of the instrument (Ch. 1); the older arrangement opens by *commanding* its abandonment — and the instrument it names, 辯, is the one the circle at the base defeats. The unit-arrangement within the bundle is editorial; the sequence within the unit is physical. Section-break data adds: chapters 15→64 and 64→56 flow with no marker — originally continuous teaching.

Verbal and stamp discipline

In prose without ::, correspondence is “to me, that looks just like...,” never “X is Y.” 也 (the Guodian 也者...也 definitional stamp) :: the derivation’s own ≡; the multi-century stripping of 也 (Guodian → Mawangdui → received) is the tradition treating theorems as observations, one copyist at a time — documented at the engine lines themselves (Ch. 40, above).

Open checksum items

- 反/復 — which return-word names return-of-structure and which return-of-place. — lexical; the structural stake is reduced
- 恆/常 — invariance-across-frames (恆, per the 互 paleography) vs. invariance-within-frame (常).
- 生/成 — the child-origin obtaining vs. the child frame completing (大器曼成).
- 亡/無 — relational absence as a third absence-type; candidate referent: the parent-frame reading of a P_n whose child obtains.
- 溺 — the interpretive ladder, unfilled.
- **The Mawangdui facsimiles** — the one outstanding errand behind a scored result. — blocks only the dating of the Ch. 40 emendation

v9.3 — *the chains state the framework as currently known; the editorial record holds how it got here.*